EasyModeBtw manual

Play any scale on the white keys, as chords, strums or arpeggios. A MIDI effect for Linux: the white keys play the notes of the scale you pick with its root on middle C, and each key can play a chord of the scale instead, strummed like a guitar or broken into an arpeggio on the beat.

Version 1.0.0. To install it, see the README.

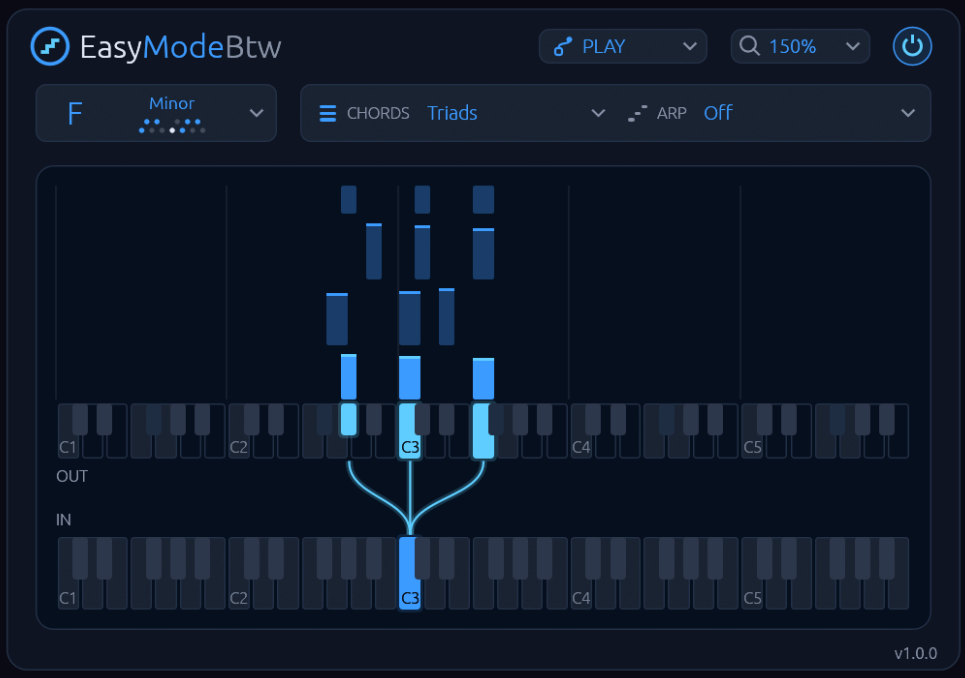
Getting started
The controls
How to use it
Good to know
Troubleshooting

Getting started

EasyModeBtw goes **in front of an instrument**, because it changes the notes the instrument receives.

- **Bitwig Studio:** put it in the Note FX slot of an instrument track, or anywhere before the instrument in the device chain.
- **Other hosts:** use it as a MIDI effect (a CLAP note effect) in front of an instrument.

Choose a KEY and a SCALE, then play the white keys from middle C upwards: every note is in the scale. Then set CHORDS to Triads and play the white keys again: each one plays a chord. Open the PLAY page to see which notes every key sends.



The controls

The header holds the page select (PLAY, CHORDS or ARP), the zoom select and the power switch. Below it one row holds the key and scale, CHORDS and ARP; under that is the page.

Control	Range	Default	What it does
Power switch (top right)	On / Off	On	Off, every event passes through unchanged.
KEY	C to B	C	The scale's root: the note middle C plays.
SCALE	14 scales	Major	The scale the white keys walk through.
CHORDS	Off, Triads, Sevenths, Sus2, Sus4, Add9, Jazz, Bossa, Soul, Folk, Power	Off	Off plays one note per key; the others a chord on every key.
ARP	Off, Up, Down, Up-Down, Converge, As Played, Chord, Random, Piano	Off	Off sends each key's note or chord at once; the others play it one note after another on the beat.
Strum switch (CHORDS page)	On / Off	Off	Off, a chord's notes start together.
STRUM (CHORDS page)	0 to 100 ms	20 ms	How long a three-note chord takes to strum, first note to last. Drag on the strum display to set it.
Strum direction (CHORDS page)	Up and down, Up, Down	Up and down	Which way the strums go.
Strum voicing (CHORDS page)	Close, Guitar	Close	How a strummed chord is laid out.
RATE (ARP page)	1/4, 1/8., 1/8, 1/8T, 1/16, 1/16T, 1/32	1/16	How far apart the arp's steps are.
RANGE (ARP page)	1 to 4	1	How many times the run plays, each time higher.
STEP (ARP page)	Octave, 2nd, 3rd, 4th, 5th, 6th	Octave	How far each repeat climbs: an octave, or that far up the scale, so it never leaves the key.
LENGTH (ARP page)	0.05 to 2 steps	0.5 step	How long each note lasts. 1 step lasts until the next note; more overlaps it.
HOLD (ARP page)	On / Off	Off	Let go and the arp plays on, until the next chord you play after letting every key go.
RHYTHM (ARP page)	Straight and 12 rhythms		Loads a rhythm into the step ring.
Step ring (ARP page)	1 to 32 steps	16, all playing	Which steps play and how loud. Saved with the project.
Zoom (header)	100 to 200 %	100 %	Sizes the window.

The version is in the bottom-right corner, and clicking the logo opens the plugin's page.

How to use it

What the white keys play

Every white key is one step of the scale. Middle C (C3, MIDI note 60) plays the root, the next white key up plays the next note of the scale, and white keys below middle C walk down it. With CHORDS off, black keys play nothing.

Scale	White keys C3 D3 E3 F3 G3 A3 B3 C4 play
C Major	C3 D3 E3 F3 G3 A3 B3 C4 (unchanged)
F Natural Minor	F3 G3 Ab3 Bb3 C4 Db4 Eb4 F4
G Major	G2 A2 B2 C3 D3 E3 F#3 G3

Roots C to F sit on or above middle C, and F# to B just below it, so the playable range stays centred. A five-note pentatonic repeats every five white keys, so your hands cover more than an octave for the same reach, which makes fast runs easy.

Chromatic plays every key, black ones too, each its own note moved so middle C plays the root: in C, the keyboard as it is.

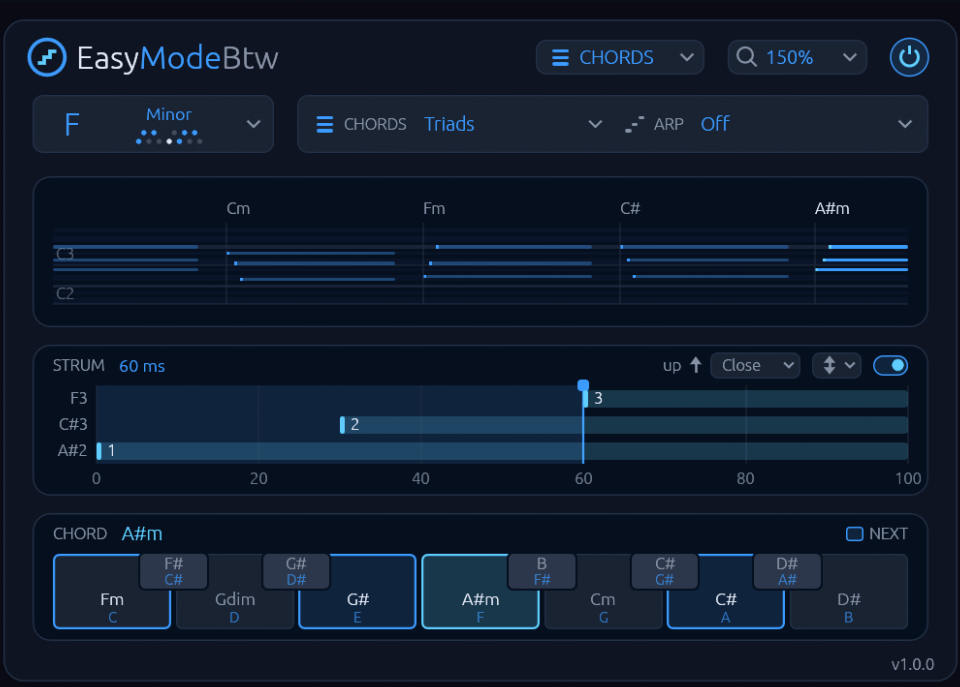
Chords

With CHORDS on, each key plays a chord built on its note.

- Triads, Sevenths, Sus2, Sus4, Add9: the scale's own chords. In C major the white keys play C Dm Em F G Am B°.
- Jazz, Bossa, Soul, Folk: the chord that genre most often puts on each note, counted from thousands of lead sheets. In C major, Jazz plays Dm7 on D, G7 on G, Cmaj7 on C and A7 on A.
- Power: the root and a perfect fifth on every key, as rock plays it.

The black keys play a major chord on their own note (bII, bIII, #IV, bVI, bVII), the chords songs borrow from outside the key. Each chord is voiced to move as little as it can from the one before, so a progression sounds smooth without thinking about inversions.

The CHORDS page shows the last four seconds of notes with each chord's name, the strum, and a key map: one octave of keys, each naming the chord it plays. The chord sounding glows on its key, and three chords that would sound good next are lit on theirs. Click a key on the map to hear its chord: near its top it plays soft, near its foot loud.



Strum

Turn on the switch on the strum display and a chord's notes start one after another, as a guitarist strums. STRUM is a three-note chord's strum; more notes take longer, fewer less. Low to high the notes come evenly; high to low they speed up, as an up stroke does. Start around 20 to 40 ms for a soft strum and 60 to 100 ms for a slow, harp-like one.

The direction select picks up and down in turn, only up or only down. The voicing select lays each chord out **Close**, near the chord before, or as a **Guitar** grips it: the root low in the bass, then the fifth, the root or seventh, the third and the fifth again. The strum only delays notes, so it adds no latency.

Arpeggiator

With ARP on, each key's note, or with CHORDS its chord, plays one note after another on the host's beat. While the transport stands it runs at the host's tempo from the first key.

- **Up, Down, Up-Down, Converge, As Played, Random:** the chord's notes in that order.
- **Chord:** the whole chord on every step; with the strum on, each step is strummed, up and down in turn, like a strumming hand.
- **Piano:** the way pop pianists break a chord: root, fifth, octave, then the third and fifth above, weaving back down, the top note loudest.

RANGE plays the run up to four times, each time higher by STEP. A chord played a little late still starts on its root.

The **ARP page** has the step ring. Click a step to turn it on or off, drag it towards the centre to make it softer and away to make it louder, and double-click it for full. Drag around the ring elsewhere to turn the rhythm, and drag the number of steps up or down to change it. RHYTHM loads a pattern into the ring: Straight, eight of the commonest broken-chord bars in pop piano, and the tresillo, cinquillo, bossa and bell rhythms.



The PLAY page

The PLAY page shows what EasyModeBtw does to your playing. The keys you press are on the lower keyboard, the notes sent on the upper one, with a thread from each key to every note it started, and the notes sent rise above. Click or drag on the lower keyboard to play with the mouse.

Notes played with the mouse go out of the plugin like any it sends; a DAW records them only where it records the plugin's output.

Good to know

- **Latency:** none. The strum and the arp only delay notes.
- **Automation:** KEY, SCALE, CHORDS and ARP changes take effect at the exact sample they are drawn at.
- **Saved projects:** a project saved with 0.1.x plays as before, except one saved with SCALE on Chromatic, which now plays every key.
- **Changing settings while you play:** a held note keeps sounding until you let go of its key, and then the right notes end, so nothing gets stuck. Switching ARP or the power switch ends what sounds; press the keys again.
- **Other MIDI:** pitch bend, mod wheel and other CCs, channel pressure and program changes pass through untouched.
- **Zoom:** the project remembers it, and a new window opens at the zoom you last chose in any PluginsBTW plugin.
- **Hosts:** the CLAP passes `clap-validator`.
- **Display:** X11, or XWayland on a Wayland desktop, with a Vulkan driver.

Troubleshooting

- **The plugin doesn't show up:** check that `easymodebtw.clap` is in `~/.clap` or `/usr/lib/clap`, then rescan plugins in your DAW.

- **The editor window stays black or doesn't open:** check that a Vulkan driver is installed. The `vulkaninfo` tool from `vulkan-tools` should list your GPU. Bitwig Studio writes plugin errors to `~/.BitwigStudio/log/engine.log`.